

EnglishPod365 0273

The Weekend - The Zodiac and Horoscopes

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Complete lesson transcript

Hello everyone and welcome to EnglishPod. My name is Marco.

My name is Catherine and we're talking about the stars today.

That's right. Today we're going to talk about a very popular subject. Many people believe in the horoscope.

So a horoscope is basically a system, a very old system of determining your future and describing your personality. And so it all depends on when you were born and where you were born. So what stars were in the sky when you were born.

That's right. So basically, as many of you may know, there are 12 signs and we're going to talk about a couple of them and a little bit more about horoscopes and this, I don't know, I guess it's kind of like a branch of science or...

Pseudo-science.

Pseudo-science.

Yeah, I don't think there's much testing that's going on, but it's definitely something that a lot of people believe in. So let's take a listen to today's dialogue and we'll be back in a moment to talk more about it.

Hey, Lydia, what are you reading?

I'm looking at my horoscope for this month. My outlook is very positive. It says that I should take a vacation to someplace exotic and that I will have a passionate summer fling.

What are you talking about? Let me see that. What are horoscopes?

It's a prediction of your month based on your zodiac sign. You have a different sign for the month and date you were born in. I was born on April 15th, so I'm an Aries. When were you born?

January 5th.

Let's see. You're a Capricorn. It says that you'll be feeling stress at work, but you could see new exciting developments in your love life. Looks like we'll both have interesting summers.

That's bogus. I don't feel any stress at work and my love life is practically non-existent.

This zodiac stuff is all a bunch of nonsense.

No it's not. Your astrology sign can tell you a lot about your personality. See, it says that an Aries is energetic and loves to socialize.

Well you certainly match those criteria, but they're so broad they could apply to anyone.

What does it say about me?

A Capricorn is serious minded and practical. She likes to do things in conventional ways.

That sounds just like you!

Alright we're back. So a very interesting dialogue between these two girls talking about one of them believing in the horoscope and the other one doesn't. But they mentioned a lot of interesting things, so we're going to have two language takeaways today. Let's start with language takeaway part one.

Language takeaway

Alright, so one of the most common things you'll hear when we talk about the horoscope in English is an outlook. And an outlook can be positive or negative. So what exactly is an outlook?

Well, if you notice Lydia said, my outlook is very positive. So basically she's talking about her future.

Alright, so the way that she sees the future or the way that the horoscope talks about the future is a positive one. So you could say, you know those eight balls? They're black and they have like a message and you shake it and it gives you a message.

You ask a question I think sometimes.

You ask a question and it says outlook positive.

That's right.

Outlook negative. So that means in your near future things will either be positive or negative.

So I guess you can apply it for example to a company. You say that a company has a positive outlook.

Or even a person. You know he's a very positive person so he has a positive outlook. He thinks good things are going to happen.

Okay, very good. So talking about horoscopes, obviously we must mention the 12 zodiac signs.

Okay, so each month has its own sign and they're not exactly the months. They're a little bit different but each sign is kind of an animal or a symbol.

That's right.

So for example, a lot of August is part of the Leo sign in English. That's the lion.

And so the lion is the animal, the zodiac.

So the zodiac sign is one of these signs. Like Leo is one of the zodiac signs. And I guess all 12 signs are considered the zodiac or the horoscope.

Exactly and you can actually talk about the zodiac in terms of other cultures. There is a Chinese zodiac. So we could say it's the year of the horse. But that's a little bit different from what we're talking about here with the Western horoscope.

Okay, very good. So all of this actually comes down to the, as we say, the pseudoscience or the branch called astrology.

Astrology. So this is a very hard word for some people to remember because they want to say astronomy. But it's different. Astronomy is the scientific study of the skies, the stars, planets, things like that. Astrology is different. It's what we're talking about here, the horoscope and reading the stars to understand what our personal futures will hold for us.

That's right. So astronomy is an exact science part of, I guess, physics where you talk about the stars or the composition of the stars and their movements. Whereas in astrology we're talking about zodiacs and horoscopes and basically what star was in the sky when you were born but in a different way. It's not very scientific.

That's right. So astrology is normally what you would see in the newspaper when you're trying to find your horoscope, astrology or horoscope.

And actually every time you read the newspaper, if you look up your zodiac sign, it makes a prediction about your day or your week or maybe even sometimes the month or year.

That's right. And so prediction is basically a guess about what will happen for you.

That's right. So many times you see that the horoscope will say finances are in trouble, be careful with how you spend your money. So they're making a prediction that in the future maybe you're going to have money problems so you have to be careful.

Exactly or in the dialogue you will have a passionate summer fling. This is a prediction.

It has not yet happened. It will happen.

That's right. That's right. A prediction. So now talking a little bit more about the zodiac signs that we saw in the dialogue, we mentioned two, Aries and Capricorn.

So a lot of people who believe in astrology say that astrological signs are broken up.

They're divided into different kinds of sign. We have water signs, air signs, earth signs and fire signs. One of the famous fire signs is Aries, right?

Aries. It's like the god of war in the Greek mythology.

That's right. So it's pronounced Aries. Aries.

A-R-I-E-S. Aries. That's right.

And the other one is a Capricorn. Capricorn. So that's like a goat?

Yeah. It's kind of like a ram. A ram.

So an earth sign. That's right. So there are 12. These are just two of them and obviously there are a lot more. I guess off the top of my head we have Taurus or Leo. There's also a Scorpio.

Sagittarius. Sagittarius.

Gemini. Gemini, which are like twins, twin people.

There's Pisces. Virgo.

And Virgo, the Virgin. And I don't know if we're missing anything.

I can't think now. We'll have to talk about it at the very end of today's lesson. But we actually have some interesting things to talk about in a minute here. We have to talk about the personality characteristics that are common when you're talking about different zodiac signs. Okay. So before we get to that, let's listen to our dialogue again. Hey, Lydia. What are you reading?

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Let's see. You're a Capricorn. It says that you'll be feeling stress at work, but you could see new exciting developments in your love life. Looks like we'll both have interesting summers. That's bogus. I don't feel any stress at work and my love life is practically non-existent. This zodiac stuff is all a bunch of nonsense. No, it's not. Your astrology sign can tell you a lot about your personality. See? It says that an Aries is energetic and loves to socialize.

Well, you certainly match those criteria, but they're so broad they could apply to anyone.

What does it say about me? A Capricorn is serious-minded and practical.

She likes to do things in conventional ways. That sounds just like you.

Alright, we're back. So now, let's take a look at these personality traits on Language Takeaway Part 2.

Language Takeaway

Alright, so one of the great words that we heard in today's dialogue was exotic. This is not necessarily describing a person, but usually things or clothes or places. In this

instance, it was some place exotic. What's an exotic place?

It's basically a place that's very unique and I guess it's kind of not common to go there or to find. For example, many people talk about an exotic getaway going to the jungle because it's so exotic. You have so many strange animals and plants and everything is so unfamiliar.

Right, so in my mind, Tahiti is very exotic. It's full of jungle and there's also beaches and it's very unusual for someone who's from America because it's just so far away.

That's right, exotic. So, someone can also have an exotic personality because maybe they're a little bit strange or not strange but not so common, maybe unique.

Yeah, although exotic is usually kind of a sexy thing when you're talking about people.

You know, she looks very exotic. That means she doesn't look like everybody else here.

That's right. But another adjective to describe someone's personality is somebody that's very energetic.

All right, so energetic sounds like the word energy. That's because they're related. So, someone who's energetic has lots of energy. He or she likes to do a lot of things and wants to always go places. You know the energetic person at your office. They always drink coffee.

Maybe they make everyone else really tired just listening to them.

That's right. And actually, a person that's energetic usually also loves to socialize.

That's right. So, loves to means they like to but they like it a lot, right? But to socialize means to talk to other people or to go to parties or to meet new people.

So if it's a verb, to socialize means to talk to people, to meet people, to greet people.

You love to have contact with other people.

So yeah, you're right. Very, very common for people who are energetic.

Okay. And what about someone that's practical? What is that like?

Someone who's practical does a lot of things. Maybe someone who's practical always comes to their activities prepared. So in my car, I'm very practical. I have extra water and a spare tire. But you can also say, I'm a very practical person. I like to do things that I can achieve as opposed to someone who always wants to do things that they can't really achieve.

Okay. So a practical person is usually very realistic and very down to earth. Maybe someone that's practical, if they're going on a trip, they'll only take what's necessary, not more than they need.

Yeah, exactly. Let me give you a good example. I like to go hiking and sometimes I see women who have not made very practical decisions about the shoes they wear. So I like to wear

hiking boots. These are very practical. Wearing high heels on a mountain is not very practical. That's right. Okay. Very good. Now, we also mentioned that a Capricorn is serious minded and conventional in many ways.

Someone who's serious minded maybe doesn't like to have fun and go out and do things that are silly. Someone who's serious minded is usually very practical, I think, and really has a goal, wants to achieve that goal. No time to be silly. No time to make jokes.

So it doesn't necessarily mean that the person is boring, but they're just very, as you said, practical.

That's right.

And what about that a Capricorn also likes to do things in conventional ways?

All right. So conventional means doing something in a conventional way means that you're doing it in a traditional way. So this is a thing we've always done. We've always done it in this way, and I'm going to continue to do it in this way. So the opposite is unconventional.

That means doing things in new ways, doing things with your imagination. And so something that's very conventional is something that has been established, and we're just going to continue doing it that way.

So for example, someone that gets married in a church is the conventional way, but someone that gets married while skydiving is very unconventional.

That's right. Unconventional. Absolutely.

Very good. So a lot of great vocab here. Why don't we listen to her dialogue one last time, and we'll be back to talk with you a little bit more.

Hey, Lydia, what are you reading?

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I should take a vacation to someplace exotic and that I will have a passionate summer fling.

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Alright, so talk about the horoscopes. Which sign are you?

I'm a Leo, which is actually... I don't believe in the horoscope, but I have to say, every time someone tells me about Leos, Leo the Lion, right? I agree with most of their descriptions of my personality. So, outspoken, loves to socialize, very opinionated, which means I have an opinion and I don't like to listen to other people, loves to argue very loud. So these are all qualities that I think I have, and some of them are bad, some of them are good, but you know, that's the way it is.

But you don't really believe in what magazines or newspapers say about your outlook?

Nah, I don't... yeah, the predictions are usually just basic guesses. But what about you? What's your sign?

I am a Taurus, so I was born in May.

A bull.

A bull, yes. So I'm very stubborn and very strong. I don't really know what all the characteristics about the Taurus are.

Opinionated?

Opinionated, I know that it's stubborn.

Loves to argue?

Yeah, exactly.

Doesn't like to be corrected?

Are you describing Taurus or are you describing me?

Both.

All right, so it's actually very interesting. I think in many ways, sometimes the glove does fit and someone's zodiac sign describes them very well. But again, maybe like the dialogue says, they are very broad descriptions that basically any person can relate to. Absolutely. I think that that's one of the tricks to horoscopes or to predicting someone's future. You tell them enough very vague things that maybe some of them will fit and some of them won't.

That's right.

But I'm very curious to hear about you guys. What are your signs? What's your sign? That means what's your zodiac sign?

That's right. That's actually also a very common date question people say, oh, what's your sign?

Or a pickup line.

Or a pickup line.

Hey baby, what's your sign?

To see if you're compatible, right?

Right. So let us know. We're not trying to pick you up. We're just curious. You'll find a lot of the words for the zodiac in today's lesson on our website, EnglishPod.com.

All right. We'll see you guys there.

Bye.

Do it again, do it again.